

The Gradient of Separation

On Appreciation, Faith, and the Conservative Force Toward the Soul

Author: Jefferson Richards

For: Chris Smith

Date: July 26, 2026

I. The Premise: Separation from Nature

Zach Bush, in his recent appearance on the Joe Rogan Experience, articulates a compelling framework: that the existential dread permeating modern society stems from our separation from nature. He posits that human beings were once capable of functioning as biological antennas—communicating through something akin to telepathy, performing acts of extraordinary will (the Moses archetype parting the sea). That potential, he argues, has been systematically eroded by the industrial food system and our divorce from the soil.

His illustrative example: an Amazonian tribe that lived for 40,000 years without money, whose impoverishment began not with colonization in the traditional sense, but with the introduction of high fructose corn syrup. The first taste of that synthetic sweetness catalyzed a need—a felt separation—that could not be undone.

Once you break the connection, once the separation has occurred, you internalize the need for money. And for all intents and purposes, you cannot return—other than by an act of God, across many people, at a societal level.

II. The Two-Body Model: Soul and Mind

Let us construct a thought experiment. Consider the self as a body in the ether—a single orb. Call it the *soul*. Now, the moment separation from nature occurs, a second body is dislodged from the first. Call this second body the *mind*.

Once separated, the mind can no longer rest directly upon the ground of the soul. A gap exists. And within that gap lives a question—the fundamental question of the separated being:

Why can't I catch a break?

This question is not trivial. It is the root driver of fight, flight, or freeze responses. It is what propels young people toward influencer culture, toward sensationalism, toward the hope that someone—a patron—will recognize their stewardship of the little they have and entrust them with more.

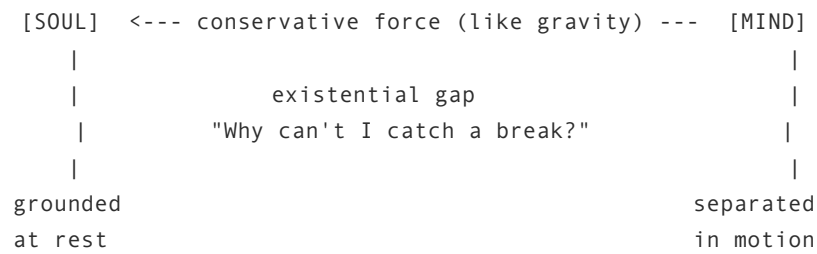


Figure 1. The conservative force drawing the mind back toward the soul.

There exists a conservative force—like gravity—that draws the mind back toward the soul. But this force, if unmediated, manifests as dread. The return is too fast, too violent. It results in collapse: freeze or flight.

III. The Gradient: Approach and Resistance

Chris, you introduced this framework: that there is a *gradient of resistance* and a *gradient of approach* when encountering new experiences. Your focus is on reducing the gradient of approach—not to cease approaching, but to lessen the steepness of the engagement.

In tactical terms: **Approach** → **Formation** → **Execution**.

The question becomes: what reduces these gradients such that the conservative force back to the soul does not overwhelm the system?

IV. The See-Desire-Take Markov Chain

Consider a Markov chain of states: **See** → **Desire** → **Take**. If we know the current state, we can estimate the probability of transition to the next state. Modern society is engineered to maximize these transition probabilities:

- Nightlife rituals designed around visual stimulation
- Leisure signaling (physique, tan) as the new fast fashion—per Bourdieu's *Distinction*
- Social media as taste expression, per Kant's *Critique of Judgment*—where beauty disrupts priorities

"I would walk 500 miles, I would walk 500 more"—The Proclaimers are quantifying how much her beauty disrupted his priorities. That is a quantifiable expression of beauty.

— Artistic reference: The Proclaimers, "I'm Gonna Be (500 Miles)"

People invest their experiences online hoping to catch a break—a twisted inversion of the parable of talents. The better question is not *why don't I make more money?* but rather *why am I not trusted with more of our resources?*

V. What Christianity Provides: Reducing the Gradient

What the practice and postures of worship—specifically in the Abrahamic tradition, and in my experience the God of Jacob—provides is a reduction in those transition probabilities. The probability that *seeing* transitions to *desire* is reduced. The probability that *desire* transitions to *taking* is reduced.

Meditating on the suffering of Jesus, on his relationship to a society that leveraged sound bites (then as now) to further legitimacy—this is a practice of rewiring. The relationship between a good father and son, that unconditional love, is the best representation of the mercy God extends to those who miss the mark.

Think of it like the Willie Nelson song: "I thought about you, Lord." That's the good man. That's Jesus as the good man.

— Artistic reference: Willie Nelson

This is not exclusive to Christianity. The Bhagavad Gita expresses it through duty and yoga. The Quran through fidelity and pure faith. The Stoics through relinquishing control over others' perception—understanding that fame, fortune, and power are neither good nor bad because they happen to both good and bad people.

VI. The Result: Appreciation and Faith as the Medium

Core thesis: Appreciation and faith are what make the separation of mind and soul *tolerable*. They reduce the gradient such that the conservative force drawing you back to the soul does not result in collapse. You can return restfully, comfortably—and choose **fight** (maintaining morale) rather than freeze or flight.

Different people from different parts of the world will need different symbols, cultural practices, and networks of people to rewire themselves toward appreciation and faith. But it is appreciation and faith that reduce the gradient, making the return to soul a gentle descent rather than a free fall.

When the question arises—*can I catch a break?*—it no longer carries the force to dismantle. The mind approaches the soul without being annihilated by the approach.

VII. On Practical Possibility: Indigenous Language Preservation and Symbol Propagation

Ibrahim (the Egyptian researcher) proposes injecting indigenous hieroglyphic characters into 5G signal architectures—that these symbols can articulate within the environment and propagate waves that carry meaning. This is 100% possible as a technical matter. The probability that it can actually *remedy* the separation? My intuition gives it approximately **26.3%**.

This intuition comes from the work behind lingualint.com—a natural language processing tool that applies semantic algebra across 26 languages. Its mission is to preserve indigenous languages: the concepts, subjects, and phenomenology embedded within them that cannot be preserved any other way.

The LinguaLint Approach

1. Engage with schema.org to establish semantic primes drawn from indigenous languages
2. Build a linter that offers indigenous language expressions when a concept or phenomenology is articulated
3. Normalize indigenous terminology through consumer packaged goods branding—e.g., using an indigenous word for a specific lifecycle stage of a blueberry, much as tea uses green, red, yellow, black for its stages

VIII. MangoLint: Proof of Concept

[MangoLint](#) is a cultural linguistics linter powered by AI that identifies natural ingredients in text and provides indigenous synonyms with rich cultural context. Built with Amazon Bedrock (Claude 3 Sonnet) and Flask.

The system employs an *Indigenous Linguist and Brand Anthropologist* AI persona with expertise in traditional ecological knowledge, ethnobotany, linguistic anthropology, and brand storytelling through cultural authenticity.

How It Works

1. Input text is analyzed for natural ingredients (fruits, herbs, spices, plants, minerals)
2. For each ingredient, the system provides 3–5 indigenous/traditional synonyms from diverse global cultures (Native American, African, Asian, Latin American, Pacific Islander, Middle Eastern)
3. Each synonym includes: the term, language, culture, definition, and contextual nuances (ripeness stages, preparation methods, seasonal variations, medicinal vs. culinary uses)
4. An enhanced brand statement is generated that naturally integrates the indigenous terminology

Example Transformation

INPUT: "Our pizza uses fresh mushrooms, peppers, and onions"

OUTPUT: "Our artisan pizza celebrates the earth's bounty with fresh hongos (mushrooms), vibrant chiles (peppers), and aromatic cebollas (onions) – a harmonious blend of traditional ingredients crafted with cultural reverence."

Figure 2. MangoLint transforming commodity descriptions into culturally-rooted brand language.

The commercial thesis: consumer packaged goods companies could use indigenous terms to name lifecycle-specific ingredients—just as tea has green, red, yellow, black for its stages of curation and fermentation. A blueberry at its optimum harvest stage could carry the indigenous name from the tribe that cultivated it for centuries. MangoLint provides the tooling to make this normalization possible at scale.

Repository: github.com/jeffy893/mangolint

Stack: Python 3.10+, Flask, Amazon Bedrock (Claude 3 Sonnet), boto3

Status: Working proof of concept with real-time analysis, caching, and brand statement generation

IX. The Morale Agent Model: Boundary Conditions for Network Vitality

The Morale Agent Model is an agent-based simulation that tests a hypothesis directly relevant to the gradient argument above: communication networks—the kind Conway's Law describes—need active boundary conditions to stay alive. Not rules that prevent transactions. *Boundaries that encourage them.*

Dead networks aren't poor. They're demoralized.

Model Parameters

100 agents, 300 rounds of bilateral transactions. Willingness to transact is driven by morale—a function of relative wealth position. Wealthier agents carry a structural edge (information, leverage, network position). Three scenarios are tested:

Results

The Gini coefficient measures inequality in a distribution on a scale from 0 to 1: 0 means perfect equality (everyone holds the same amount), 1 means perfect inequality (one agent holds everything). It is derived from the Lorenz curve—the gap between the actual cumulative distribution of wealth and the line of perfect equality. For real-world context: Scandinavian countries sit around 0.25–0.30, the United States around 0.39–0.41, and South Africa around 0.63.

SCENARIO	GINI	MORALE	TRANSACTIONS
No Boundaries (Free Market)	0.88	0.52	21,908
Soft Boundaries (Redistribution)	0.40	0.75	26,562
Active Boundaries (Incentives)	0.38	0.92	33,946

Figure 3. Active boundaries produce 62% more transactions than the free market, with the highest morale and lowest inequality.

The Three Active Boundary Mechanisms

1. **Participation Morale Floor** — Agents who transacted last round cannot have morale drop below a threshold. The act of showing up is itself rewarded. This is the key mechanism: engagement is sustained by making engagement rewarding.
2. **Structural Advantage Dampening** — The wealthy still win more often, but their edge compounds at 1/3 the rate. Competition stays; runaway dominance doesn't.
3. **Network Vitality Feedback** — When transaction volume is high, everyone gets a morale boost. The system rewards its own health. Plus a cross-wealth *diversity dividend*: transacting across large wealth gaps earns both parties a bonus, weighted toward the poorer party.

The Conway's Law insight: Your network's output mirrors its communication structure. But communication requires willingness. Willingness requires morale. Morale requires believing participation is worth it.

Three Principles

- Reward participation itself, not just outcomes
- Dampen structural advantage compounding—don't eliminate competition, prevent runaway dominance

- Build feedback loops between network health and individual benefit

Boundary conditions aren't constraints on freedom. They're the infrastructure that keeps freedom meaningful.

Repository: github.com/jeffy893/riskrunners/.../moraleAgentModel

Stack: Python, NumPy, Matplotlib

More models: riskrunners.com

X. On the CDC Morale Model and Biotics

The CDC's morale model addresses the propagation of what we might call *biotics*—organisms that persist in our systems due to the interplay of actives and passives. The aristocratic separation from soil (syphilis running through the aristocracy as a systemic issue rather than merely an infectious one) mirrors the broader pattern: separation from the ground produces conditions for pathology.

What we can guarantee: no one is statically inactive. People oscillate between active and passive states. People can be maintained as active. The redistribution question is secondary to the boundary question—proper boundaries that sustain transaction, morale, and fight.

The Morale Agent Model provides computational evidence for this claim: when boundaries are designed to reward participation and dampen compounding advantage, agents *choose* to remain active. The network stays alive not through coercion but through the felt experience that participation is worth it—which is precisely what appreciation and faith provide at the individual spiritual level.

References and Artistic Touchstones

- **Zach Bush, MD** — Joe Rogan Experience (2026). On biological systems, separation from nature, and existential dread.
- **Pierre Bourdieu** — *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste* (1979). On leisure signaling and class expression.
- **Immanuel Kant** — *Critique of Judgment* (1790). On beauty disrupting priorities and the expression of taste.
- **The Bhagavad Gita** — On duty (dharma) and yoga as modes of reunion.
- **The Quran** — On fidelity and pure faith.
- **Stoic Philosophy** (Epictetus, Marcus Aurelius) — On relinquishing control over perception.
- **Friedrich Nietzsche** — The Übermensch concept as pride-driven response to separation.
- **Mary Shelley** — *Frankenstein* (1818). The creature rejected by its creator as analog for nature's rejection.
- **Jane Austen** — On solvency, clothing cost, and social signaling in earlier economies.
- **Willie Nelson** — "I Thought About You, Lord." The good man's devotion.
- **The Proclaimers** — "I'm Gonna Be (500 Miles)." Quantifying the disruption of beauty on priorities.
- **The Parable of Talents** — Matthew 25:14–30. Stewardship and trust.
- **LinguaLint** — lingualint.com. NLP tool for indigenous language preservation across 26 languages.

- **MangoLint** — github.com/jeffy893/mangolint. Cultural linguistics linter — proof of concept for LLM-driven indigenous ingredient translation.
- **Morale Agent Model** — github.com/jeffy893/riskrunners/.../moraleAgentModel. Agent-based simulation of boundary conditions, morale, and network vitality.
- **RiskRunners** — riskrunners.com. Agent-based simulation models.
- **Schema.org** — schema.org. Semantic web vocabulary standards.

Composed as a meditation · July 26, 2026 · Jefferson Richards

For Chris Smith